

HOUSE No. 298

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

PRESENTED BY:

Antonio F. D. Cabral

To the Honorable Senate and House of Representatives of the Commonwealth of Massachusetts in General Court assembled:

The undersigned legislators and/or citizens respectfully petition for the adoption of the accompanying bill:

An Act to promote school centered neighborhood development.

PETITION OF:

NAME:	DISTRICT/ADDRESS:	DATE ADDED:
<i>Antonio F. D. Cabral</i>	<i>13th Bristol</i>	<i>1/17/2025</i>
<i>Vanna Howard</i>	<i>17th Middlesex</i>	<i>1/30/2025</i>
<i>Rodney M. Elliott</i>	<i>16th Middlesex</i>	<i>2/4/2025</i>
<i>Christopher Hendricks</i>	<i>11th Bristol</i>	<i>2/4/2025</i>
<i>Mary S. Keefe</i>	<i>15th Worcester</i>	<i>3/5/2025</i>

HOUSE No. 298

By Representative Cabral of New Bedford, a petition (accompanied by bill, House, No. 298) of Antonio F. D. Cabral and others relative to school centered neighborhood developments. Community Development and Small Businesses.

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court
(2025-2026)

An Act to promote school centered neighborhood development.

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Court assembled, and by the authority of the same, as follows:

1 SECTION 1. The General Laws are hereby amended by inserting after chapter 40Y the
2 following chapter:-

3
4 Chapter 40Z. School-centered neighborhood development

5 Section 1. Definitions

6 As used in this chapter, the following words shall, unless the context clearly requires
7 otherwise, have the following meanings:—

8 "Community school", a public school that establishes a set of strategic partnerships
9 between the school and other community resources that leverage shared accountability,
10 collaborative leadership, capacity building, and family and community engagement, to promote

student achievement, and the well-being of students, families, educators, and neighborhood residents through a variety of engaging practices including the provision of wraparound services.

“Community Schools strategy”, a strategy that transforms a school into a community school where educators, local community members, families, and students work together to establish shared vision and goals to strengthen conditions for student learning and healthy development, including but not limited to the organization of in- and out-of-school resources, supports, and student opportunities.

“Council”, the Massachusetts Interagency Council on School-Centered Neighborhood Development, established pursuant to section 2.

“Municipal children’s cabinets”, a standing body that includes municipal agencies, nonprofits, and private sector partners formed to map the cradle-to-career pipeline serving children and families in the community, identify gaps, and implement strategies to close these gaps. In addition to municipal-wide approaches, these strategies may include supporting the production and implementation of school-centered neighborhood development plans for discrete neighborhoods within the municipality.

"Office", the executive office of housing and livable communities.

“School-centered neighborhood development plan”, a long-term plan for the area surrounding a public school or public schools. The plan shall seek to identify opportunities to build strong mixed-income neighborhoods and schools for children and families and establish goals pursuant to these opportunities, in conformance with the general plan for the municipality. All school-centered neighborhood development plans shall incorporate strategies to ensure that

the public schools within the designated area adopt and operate according to the basic tenants of the community school model.

“Lead partner”, a nonprofit or governmental entity that is responsible for coordinating across partner organizations and driving the school-centered neighborhood development plan implementation.

“Research-practice partnerships”, collaborative, long-term relationships between researchers and practitioners that are designed to improve educational outcomes.

Section 2. The Massachusetts Interagency Council on School-Centered Neighborhood Development

There shall be established a council to be known as the Massachusetts Interagency Council on School-Centered Neighborhood Development ("the council"). The council shall consists of eighteen members: the Lieutenant Governor, who shall serve as the chair; three representatives to be appointed by the secretary of the executive office of housing and livable communities; three representatives from the education departments to be appointed by the secretary of the executive office of education; the chief executive officer of the Massachusetts Housing Finance Agency or their designee; the chief executive officer of the Massachusetts Development Finance Agency or their designee; the chief executive officer of the Massachusetts Housing Partnership or their designee; the chief executive officer of the Community Economic Development Assistance Corporation or their designee; the chief executive officer of the Massachusetts School Building Authority or their designee; a representative of the Massachusetts Association of School Superintendents; a representative of the Massachusetts Association of School Committees; two members to be appointed by the Speaker of the

Massachusetts House of Representatives; and two members to be appointed by the President of the Massachusetts Senate. All members, except for the chair, shall serve for two years, after which time they will be eligible for reappointment. All members shall not receive compensation for their service on the council. The council shall meet at the times and places to be determined by the chair.

In addition, members of the council shall meet and consult on a regular basis with individuals or groups who have specific expertise in any area to be addressed by the council.

(b) The council shall have the authority to build long-term partnerships to further local school-centered neighborhood development plans, including but not limited to: reviewing existing programs and policies relating to community schools, municipal children's cabinets, school-centered neighborhood development plans, and school facility construction; recommending strategies to target state housing and community development investments to ensure that these resource allocations encourage and assist municipalities working collaboratively to implement school-centered neighborhood development plans; recommending changes to state tenant selection guidelines to ensure that these regulations further efforts to implement school-centered neighborhood development plans, in accordance with state and federal fair housing law; recommending legislation or changes to regulation of any agency of the Commonwealth to improve the operation of the policies of the Commonwealth relating to the development of mixed-income neighborhoods and schools; and monitoring the progress of any initiatives undertaken in response to the council's recommendations.

(c) The council shall report any findings or recommendations, including any recommendations for legislation or regulation, to the Governor at such periods as determined by the Chair.

Section 3. The Fund for Stronger Neighborhoods and Schools

There is hereby established and set up on the books of the commonwealth a separate fund to be known as the Fund for Stronger Neighborhoods and Schools. The fund shall be administered by the secretary of the executive office of housing and livable communities. The purpose of this fund shall be to support collaborative efforts to strengthen neighborhoods and schools. The fund shall consist of: (i) any revenues or other financing sources directed to the fund by appropriation; (ii) bond revenues or other monies authorized by the general court and specifically designated to be credited to the fund; (iii) any income derived from the investment of amounts credited to the fund or repayment of loans from the fund; (iv) funds from public and private sources including, but not limited to gifts, federal or private grants, donations, rebates and settlements received by the commonwealth that are specifically designated to be credited to the fund; and (v) all other amounts credited or transferred into the fund from any other source Any unexpended balances in the fund at the end of the fiscal year shall not revert back to the General Fund and shall be available for expenditures in the subsequent fiscal year.

(b) Such funds shall be used to support lead partner organizations, children's cabinets, community schools, and other local initiatives to strengthen neighborhoods and schools. Funds may also be used to provide third-party technical assistance and other professionals services to launch children's cabinets or community schools, to produce school-

centered neighborhood development plans or community schools strategies, or to research and evaluate any of the preceding practices.

(c) Annually, not later than December 1, the secretary of the executive office of housing and livable communities shall report on the activities of the fund to the clerks of the house of representatives and the senate and to the house and senate committees on ways and means. The report shall include an accounting of expenditures made from the fund with a description of the authorized purpose of each expenditure, an accounting of amounts credited to the fund and any unexpended balance remaining in the fund.

Section 4. Data and Evaluation

Children's cabinets and lead partners may create research-practice partnerships to improve their understanding of the cradle-to-career pipeline at the municipal or neighborhood level. The council shall support these local efforts by coordinating with relevant state agencies to link local data to data systems maintained by state agencies, in compliance with all state and federal laws to protect individual privacy.